

# RailCore Growth Pathway Program: Leader Track

## Course Type

Inquiry-Based Strategic Alignment Workshop

## Audience

Senior leaders, department heads, HR leaders, business unit leaders, and people leaders who sponsor, communicate, and reinforce IDP adoption across teams.

## Duration

3 hours

## Delivery Mode

Instructor-led workshop / blended leadership session

## 1. Course Purpose

This Leader Track prepares leaders to sponsor, model, and reinforce Individual Development Planning across the organization.

Instead of presenting IDPs as an HR requirement, the session uses an **inquiry-based learning approach** to help leaders first identify current talent-management challenges, then connect IDPs to talent visibility, employee growth, succession readiness, manager accountability, and business performance.

## 2. Overall Learning Goal

By the end of the session, leaders will understand IDPs as a strategic leadership tool and create practical actions to support successful IDP adoption across their teams.

## 3. Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, leaders will be able to:

1. **Identify** key talent-management challenges that IDPs can help address.
2. **Explain** how IDPs support employee growth, retention, role readiness, internal mobility, and succession planning.
3. **Describe** the IDP journey between employees and managers.
4. **Define** what effective IDP adoption looks like beyond completion rate.
5. **Analyze** common barriers to IDP adoption and select leadership responses.
6. **Communicate** the purpose and expectations of IDPs in a way that builds buy-in.
7. **Interpret** IDP adoption data to identify completion, quality, and follow-up risks.
8. **Create** a leadership action plan to reinforce IDP adoption after training.

## 4. Instructional Strategy

The course uses an inquiry-based learning flow:

**Ask → Surface → Connect → Apply**

| Stage   | Purpose                                                   |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Ask     | Invite leaders to reflect on real talent challenges       |
| Surface | Let leaders name current pain points and risks            |
| Connect | Facilitate the link between those issues and IDP value    |
| Apply   | Have leaders create messages, responses, and action plans |

This keeps the session leader-centered while still guiding participants toward the intended learning outcomes.

The trainer should avoid starting with long explanations. Instead, each major section should begin with a strategic question, followed by discussion, facilitator synthesis, and application.

## 5. Revised 3-Hour Lesson Flow

| Section | Topic                                      | Time   | Main Inquiry Question                                             | Output                    |
|---------|--------------------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 1       | Welcome & Leader Mindset                   | 10 min | What happens when employee development is left to chance?         | Shared urgency            |
| 2       | Talent Challenges Before IDPs              | 25 min | What talent-management challenges are we currently facing?        | Talent challenge map      |
| 3       | IDPs as a Strategic Talent Tool            | 25 min | How could a structured IDP process help address these challenges? | IDP value connection      |
| 4       | The IDP Journey: What Leaders Need to Know | 25 min | Where does development planning usually break down?               | IDP journey risk map      |
| 5       | Effective IDP Adoption                     | 25 min | Is completion enough to show IDP success?                         | Quality adoption criteria |
| Break   |                                            | 5 min  |                                                                   |                           |
| 6       | Barriers, Resistance, and Change Adoption  | 30 min | What resistance should we expect, and how should leaders respond? | Barrier-response plan     |
| 7       | Leader Communication and Buy-In            | 25 min | What message will help managers and employees see IDPs as useful? | Leadership message draft  |
| 8       | IDP Data, Dashboard, and Accountability    | 25 min | What does this data tell us, and what should leaders ask next?    | Dashboard interpretation  |
| Break   |                                            | 5 min  |                                                                   |                           |
| 9       | Build the IDP Leadership Playbook          | 25 min | What must leaders do after this session to make IDPs stick?       | Playbook draft            |
| 10      | Leadership Commitment & Close              | 10 min | What will I personally do to reinforce IDP adoption?              | Individual commitment     |

**Total: 3 hours**

## 6. Detailed Revised Lesson Plan

### Section 1: Welcome & Leader Mindset

**Time:** 10 minutes

#### Purpose

Set the tone for the session and position IDPs as a leadership responsibility, not only an HR process.

#### Inquiry Question

**What happens when employee development is left to chance?**

## **Learning Activity**

Facilitator asks leaders to reflect individually, then share quick responses.

Expected responses may include:

- Employees do not see career paths.
- Managers coach inconsistently.
- High-potential employees may leave.
- Skill gaps are not addressed early.
- Succession planning becomes reactive.
- Development conversations become informal or forgotten.

## **Facilitator Synthesis**

Connect participant responses to the core message:

“These are the kinds of talent risks that IDPs are designed to make visible, structured, and actionable.”

## **Output**

Shared urgency around the need for structured development planning.

# **Section 2: Talent Challenges Before IDPs**

**Time:** 25 minutes

## **Purpose**

Help leaders identify the business and talent problems that make IDPs necessary.

## **Inquiry Question**

**What talent-management challenges are we currently facing?**

## **Content Focus**

This section should not begin with IDP definitions. It begins with talent challenges.

Possible categories:

| <b>Talent Challenge</b>   | <b>Example</b>                                        |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Retention risk            | Strong employees leave because they do not see growth |
| Skill gaps                | Teams lack future-ready capabilities                  |
| Succession risk           | Few employees are ready for next-level roles          |
| Manager inconsistency     | Some managers develop people; others do not           |
| Low career visibility     | Employees do not know what growth looks like          |
| Limited internal mobility | Talent does not move across teams effectively         |

## **Activity**

### **Talent Challenge Mapping**

Leaders work in small groups and answer:

1. What talent challenge is most visible in our area?
2. What happens if we do not address it?
3. Who is affected: employees, managers, customers, operations, or the business?

## **Output**

A shared list of priority talent challenges.

## **Section 3: IDPs as a Strategic Talent Tool**

**Time:** 25 minutes

### **Purpose**

Guide leaders to connect the talent challenges they identified to the value of IDPs.

### **Inquiry Question**

**How could a structured IDP process help address these challenges?**

## Content Focus

Introduce IDPs after leaders have surfaced the problems.

IDPs help create:

| Need                 | How IDPs Help                                                    |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Visibility           | Make employee goals, skills, and development needs easier to see |
| Consistency          | Give managers and employees a common process                     |
| Accountability       | Create documented goals, actions, and follow-up                  |
| Retention            | Show employees that growth is being discussed intentionally      |
| Capability building  | Link development actions to role and business needs              |
| Succession readiness | Build future talent pipelines more deliberately                  |

## Activity

### Challenge-to-IDP Connection

Groups choose one talent challenge from Section 2 and complete:

- The challenge is:
- Why it matters:
- How IDPs could help:
- What leadership support is required:

## Output

Clear connection between IDPs and strategic talent priorities.

## Section 4: The IDP Journey — What Leaders Need to Know

**Time:** 25 minutes

### Purpose

Give leaders enough understanding of the IDP process to sponsor it, model it, and reinforce it.

## **Inquiry Question**

**Where does development planning usually break down?**

## **Content Focus**

Introduce the 5-step IDP journey:

| <b>Step</b>  | <b>What Happens</b>                                        | <b>Leader's Role</b>                         |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 1. Reflect   | Employee reflects on goals, strengths, gaps, and interests | Encourage employee ownership                 |
| 2. Discuss   | Manager and employee discuss goals and opportunities       | Set expectation for meaningful conversations |
| 3. Plan      | Employee and manager select specific development actions   | Reinforce realistic, role-connected actions  |
| 4. Document  | IDP is recorded in the system or template                  | Ensure consistency and visibility            |
| 5. Follow Up | Progress is reviewed regularly                             | Build accountability rhythm                  |

## **Activity**

### **IDP Journey Risk Map**

Leaders identify:

- Which step is most likely to fail?
- Why might it fail?
- What can leaders do to prevent that failure?

## **Output**

A map of process risks and leader responsibilities.

## **Section 5: Effective IDP Adoption**

**Time:** 25 minutes

## **Purpose**

Help leaders define successful adoption beyond simple completion numbers.

## **Inquiry Question**

**Is completion enough to show IDP success?**

## **Content Focus**

Effective adoption includes both quantity and quality.

| <b>Weak Adoption</b>                 | <b>Strong Adoption</b>                          |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| IDPs completed only because required | IDPs used to guide development conversations    |
| Vague goals                          | Specific, realistic, role-connected goals       |
| No follow-up                         | Regular check-ins and updates                   |
| Managers treat it as HR paperwork    | Managers use it as a coaching tool              |
| Leaders only track completion        | Leaders review quality, follow-up, and barriers |

## **Activity**

### **Adoption Case Comparison**

Leaders compare two fictional departments:

#### **Department A**

- 96% completion
- Most goals are generic
- Follow-up rate is low
- Employees see IDPs as paperwork

#### **Department B**

- 84% completion
- Goals are specific
- Managers hold quarterly follow-ups
- Employees report clearer development direction



Discussion:

1. Which department shows healthier adoption?
2. What would you ask each department leader?
3. What support would you provide?

## Output

Leadership criteria for meaningful IDP adoption.

## Break

**Time:** 5 minutes

## Section 6: Barriers, Resistance, and Change Adoption

**Time:** 30 minutes

### Purpose

Prepare leaders to anticipate resistance and support adoption.

### Inquiry Question

**What resistance should we expect, and how should leaders respond?**

### Content Focus

Use a simple change-adoption lens:

**Awareness → Buy-In → Action → Reinforcement**

| Stage         | Leader Responsibility                              |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Awareness     | Explain why IDPs matter                            |
| Buy-In        | Connect IDPs to real talent and business needs     |
| Action        | Set clear expectations and provide tools           |
| Reinforcement | Review progress, recognize effort, remove barriers |

## **Activity**

### **Barrier-Response Planning**

Each group selects one barrier:

- “This is just another HR task.”
- “Managers do not have time.”
- “Employees do not know what goals to choose.”
- “The system is confusing.”
- “No one follows up.”
- “Development opportunities are limited.”

Groups create:

1. Leader message
2. Support action
3. Follow-up measure

## **Output**

Practical leadership responses to adoption barriers.

## **Section 7: Leader Communication and Buy-In**

**Time:** 25 minutes

### **Purpose**

Help leaders practice communicating IDPs in a way that builds commitment.

### **Inquiry Question**

**What message will help managers and employees see IDPs as useful?**

### **Content Focus**

A strong leadership message should answer:

1. Why are we doing this?
2. What problem are we solving?
3. What is expected from managers?
4. What is expected from employees?
5. How will leaders support and follow up?

## **Activity**

### **Leadership Message Draft**

Participants draft a short message using this structure:

### **Acknowledge → Reframe → Clarify → Support**

Example:

“I understand that teams are busy, and this may feel like another process at first. The goal of IDPs is not paperwork. The goal is to make development conversations more focused, visible, and useful. Managers are expected to hold meaningful conversations and document practical next steps. Leaders will support this by providing tools, reviewing progress, and removing barriers.”

## **Output**

A leadership message that can be reused after training.

## **Section 8: IDP Data, Dashboard, and Accountability**

**Time:** 25 minutes

### **Purpose**

Help leaders use IDP data to monitor adoption and guide follow-up.

### **Inquiry Question**

**What does this data tell us, and what should leaders ask next?**

### **Content Focus**

Leaders should monitor:

- Completion rate
- IDP quality
- Follow-up rate
- Manager participation
- Common skill themes
- Development opportunity gaps

## Activity

### Dashboard Interpretation

Use a sample dashboard:

| Team                | Completion | Quality | Follow-Up | Possible Risk       |
|---------------------|------------|---------|-----------|---------------------|
| Operations          | 92%        | Medium  | 45%       | Follow-up weak      |
| Maintenance         | 70%        | High    | 80%       | Participation gap   |
| Customer Service    | 98%        | Low     | 30%       | Compliance behavior |
| Safety & Compliance | 85%        | High    | 75%       | Healthy adoption    |

Discussion questions:

1. Which team needs support first?
2. What question would you ask the department manager?
3. What leadership action would you take?
4. What follow-up rhythm should be used?

## Output

Leaders practice using IDP data for accountability, not punishment.

## Break

**Time:** 5 minutes

## **Section 9: Build the IDP Leadership Playbook**

**Time:** 25 minutes

### **Purpose**

Create a practical leadership tool that supports transfer after training.

### **Inquiry Question**

**What must leaders do after this session to make IDPs stick?**

### **Activity**

#### **IDP Leadership Playbook Draft**

Participants work in groups to draft sections of the playbook:

| <b>Playbook Section</b> | <b>Guiding Question</b>                        |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Leadership Message      | What should leaders say about IDPs?            |
| Manager Expectations    | What must managers do consistently?            |
| Employee Expectations   | What must employees own?                       |
| Common Barriers         | What resistance should we prepare for?         |
| Follow-Up Rhythm        | How often should progress be reviewed?         |
| Success Measures        | What data or evidence will show progress?      |
| Support Resources       | What tools, templates, or examples are needed? |

### **Output**

Draft **RailCore IDP Leadership Playbook**.

## **Section 10: Leadership Commitment & Close**

**Time:** 10 minutes

## **Purpose**

Move from discussion to personal leadership action.

## **Inquiry Question**

**What will I personally do to reinforce IDP adoption?**

## **Activity**

Each leader completes a commitment card:

1. One message I will communicate:
2. One adoption barrier I will address:
3. One question I will ask managers:
4. One follow-up rhythm I will use:
5. One support action I will provide:

## **Closing Message**

“IDPs become meaningful when leaders make development visible, expected, supported, and followed up.”

## **Output**

Individual leadership commitment.

# **7. What Changed from the Earlier Version**

| <b>Earlier Version</b>                 | <b>Revised Version</b>                                 |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Started more directly with IDP value   | Starts with leaders’ talent challenges                 |
| IDP positioned as training content     | IDP positioned as a solution to business/talent issues |
| Some manager-level activities included | More leader-level sponsorship and adoption work        |
| CRM practice included                  | Replaced with dashboard/accountability interpretation  |
| “Ultimate IDP Guide”                   | Upgraded to IDP Leadership Playbook                    |

|                    |                                                     |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| General discussion | Structured inquiry: Ask → Surface → Connect → Apply |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|

## 8. Design Rationale for Portfolio

I designed the Leader Track as an inquiry-based strategic alignment workshop. Since leaders bring significant workplace experience, the course does not begin by presenting IDPs as an HR requirement. Instead, leaders first examine current talent-management challenges, such as retention risk, capability gaps, succession readiness, and inconsistent development conversations. Through guided inquiry, they connect these challenges to the value of IDPs and create leadership actions to support adoption, accountability, and follow-up.